

Musing in the Twilight Hours

At this late stage in my life, I find myself ruminating more often—letting my thoughts drift into realms of curiosity, concern and quiet wonder—about the past, present and future. Not every musing has a direct bearing on the tasks or routines of daily living. Many of them simply linger as ideas and reflections that keep me company. They're not urgent. But they feel important.

One of the constants in my life has been curiosity. That urge to understand, to explore the *why* behind the *what*, has followed me since childhood. In these later years, it often expresses itself in the form of intellectual wanderings. These wonderings tend to be random, stretching across all sorts of unrelated and disconnected topics. They include both reflection and speculation.

I muse about the drift in social trust and the cruelty of our world. Or perhaps it is more of a plunge than a drift more recently. Our world has become a sadder, meaner and more pessimistic place. Someone recently pointed out how it now seems to be “dog eat dog,” with culture slowly evaporating. And I agree. I'm not sure why and how this developed. It's more complex than my reasoning. But it's real, and it's disappointing. And I honestly cannot perceive a reverse pathway. So I worry.

These reflections often give way to a deeper brooding. A pensiveness not of the hand-wringing variety, but a quiet concern for the trajectory of our society. I wouldn't call myself obsessed, but there are themes that circle my mind with increasing regularity: the tone of our politics, the widening gap between rich and poor, the erosion of civility, the fracturing of our shared understanding.

I am, by nature, a political moderate. I shy away from extremes. I don't identify with either end of the spectrum, neither the so-called “woke” nor the far-right ideologues. I value thoughtfulness over slogans. But that doesn't mean I'm indifferent.

Another dimension of my musing is a reflection on history. I am fascinated with early American history, for example – the American Revolution and the towering intellects that built a fragile experiment into a lasting nation. The 18th century in particular calls to me. I'm intrigued by the improbable genius of the Founding Fathers who were, for all their human flaws, far-sighted thinkers, philosophers of governance and students of human nature. It amazes me how many of them were not merely leaders, but true polymaths. I often wonder how the modern age stacks up, whether we still value that kind of wisdom, or whether we've traded it for something more transient.

My interest doesn't stop with American history. Ancient civilizations, too, hold my attention. I enjoy focusing on those moments when an archeological discovery upends what we thought we knew. The more I read, the more astonished I am by the technical and cultural sophistication of those who came before us. It reminds me how much we owe to those lost generations and how easily their brilliance can be underestimated.

In another particular, as an example, I have come to believe in term limits for our government officials—not from any bitterness, but from a growing sense that entrenched power calcifies. We

need fresh ideas, new voices and the humility to know when to step aside. Our institutions, once dynamic, are showing signs of ossification. That troubles me.

As does the economic chasm that seems to be widening before our eyes. The economic gap in our population is disturbing. One striking memory that refuses to leave me is a short walk some time ago from the Miami train station to a Miami Heat NBA basketball game. We passed dozens of homeless men huddled along the sidewalk, only to step minutes later into an arena where athletes command salaries in the tens of millions. The contrast was jarring. Disturbing. Their faces, the homeless and the athletes, could have belonged to the same family. And yet, the world treats them with such different outcomes. I don't know the answer. I wish I did. But it weighs on me.

The media, once a lodestar for truth, has become another source of unease for me. It feels like the professional objectivity of journalism has given way to a constant, breathless search for scandal. There seems to be a suspicious, negative slant to everything. Rather than helping us understand the world, many outlets seem bent on reinforcing our worst suspicions about it. I long for some neutral place, a platform where facts are laid bare and interpretation is left to the listener. I recently wrote a letter to the editor of our local newspaper protesting a caustic editorialized sports article that offended me. I don't want to be shielded from the truth. I just want to know that what I'm hearing *is* the truth. I was pleased that they published my letter.

Corruption, too, is a shadow that follows me around. My years in public accounting exposed me to its many shades, from the petty to the breathtakingly brazen. What troubles me is not only the corruption itself, but the way we've come to expect it. Shrugging off what would once have sparked outrage. That kind of moral erosion doesn't happen overnight. It creeps. And we barely notice.

Which leads, inevitably, to questions of morality. Our shared sense of right and wrong feels weaker than it once did. Not just in our laws, but in our conversations, our expectations, our culture. Churches, once bedrocks of community, are shrinking. I've seen it in my own congregation, where attendance is now a whisper of what it once was. I'm not a fire-and-brimstone preacher, and I'm wary of nostalgia that glosses over real progress. But I do believe that a society needs moral anchors, and when they erode, we drift. Ethics matter. So does empathy. I'm not sure what replaces the community structures we've lost, but I worry about the void they leave behind.

And more lately, my mind is often occupied by the wonder of artificial intelligence. This rapidly emerging phenomenon has so many potential ramifications it is difficult to even imagine where it may lead us as a society. I both marvel and worry.

So, I muse. These thoughts—history, society, fairness, faith, progress—aren't always connected. They don't arrive in neat essays or tidy arguments. They come as waves, as undercurrents, often when I least expect them. I don't always share them. But I carry them.

Despite my keen interest in public life, I made a decision long ago to avoid direct political activism. This determination was born partly from college experiences in student government. And I've held to that over the years. So, I therefore have retrenched to musing.

I'm not looking to convince anyone. I'm not even looking for answers anymore. I suppose I just want to be honest about what fills my mind in these twilight hours. Life has given me so much to be grateful for. But it has also given me questions that may never be answered. Still, the questions are worth asking.

So I muse.